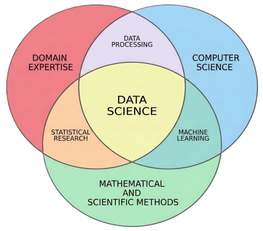
The Career of a Data Scientist: Pathways, Skills, and Industry Opportunities in the Modern Data Economy

UNIVERSITY OF LEEDS

MATH5747: Learning Skills Through Case Studies
Department of Mathematics, University of Leeds 2025 - 2026

What is a Data Scientist ?

A data scientist extracts actionable insight from complex data combining **Statistics**, **Machine learning**, and Domain expertise to drive real decisions.



Core Activities:

- Data collection, cleaning & exploration
- Build & deploy predictive models
- Translate findings into recommendations
- Communicate insights to stakeholders

Who Employs Data Scientists?

Data scientists are in demand across virtually every sector.

Technology & Internet
Google · Amazon · Microsoft · Meta
Recommendation systems · A/B testing · Ad optimisation · User analytics

Finance & Banking
JPMorgan · HSBC · Goldman Sachs
Fraud detection · Credit risk · Algorithmic trading · Customer segmentation

Healthcare & Pharma
AstraZeneca · Pfizer · Roche · NHS
Disease risk prediction · Drug discovery · Clinical trials · Medical imaging AI

Retail & E-commerce
Alibaba · Walmart · eBay
Demand forecasting · Price optimisation · Supply chain · Customer analytics

Consulting & Professional Services
Accenture · Deloitte · PwC
Business analytics · Predictive modelling · Data strategy · AI transformation

Also hiring: Government & Public Sector · Energy & Utilities · Media & Advertising · Transport · Education

Qualification and Skills

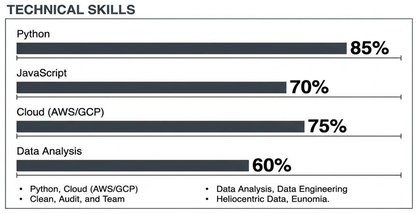
ESSENTIAL — Undergraduate Degree
Mathematics · Statistics · Computer Science
Physics · Engineering · Economics (quantitative)
"Or equivalent experience" increasingly accepted

PREFERRED — Postgraduate Degree
MSc Data Science / AI / Machine Learning
PhD valued in pharma, finance, deep tech research
Conversion MSc available for career changers

USEFUL — Certifications & Portfolios
AWS / GCP / Azure ML Engineer cert
Kaggle top 10% finishes · GitHub projects
Google Data Analytics · Coursera Deep Learning

Technical Skills by UK Job Posting Frequency

Based on analysis of 2,400+ UK Postings (2024)



Creating Soft Skills – "The Last Mile"

Data-Driven Skills

- **Data Storytelling :** translate complex outputs into actionable narratives
- **Business Acumen :** link analysis directly to commercial outcomes
- **Communication :** executive presentations
- **Critical Thinking :** question data quality, probe assumptions, identify bias
- **Ethical Reasoning :** fairness, privacy, responsible AI deployment

Domain Expertise Multiplier

Sector knowledge *significantly* increases hiring probability:

- **Finance:** Risk frameworks & regulatory knowledge
- **Healthcare:** Clinical trial design & GDPR
- **Retail:** Supply chain & customer segmentation
- **Energy:** Predictive maintenance

Career Progression

Entry Level — **Salary** £30,000 – £48,000+
UK Experience: 0–2 Years
UK Job Titles: Graduate Data Engineer, Software Developer Intern

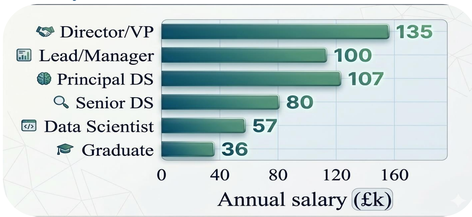
Early Career / Mid Level — **Salary** £50,000 – £85,000+
UK Experience: 2–5 Years
UK Job Titles: Data Scientist, Software Engineer, Cloud Architect

Senior Level / Advanced — **Salary** £85,000 – £140,000+
UK Experience: 5–10 Years
UK Job Titles: Senior Software Engineer, Principal Data Sci, Tech Lead

Leadership & Executive — **Salary** £140,000 – £250,000++
UK Experience: 10+ Years
UK Job Titles: VP of Engineering, Chief Data Officer (CDO), Officer (CTO)

Stage	Key Focus
Graduate	Data cleaning; EDA; support senior scientists
Data Scientist	Own end-to-end projects; deploy models
Senior Data Scientist	Technical lead; mentor juniors; solve complex problems
Principal	Research; strategy; deep specialist expertise
Lead / Manager	Team leadership; project delivery; stakeholder liaison
Director	Business strategy; data vision
CDO / VP	Org-wide data strategy; C-suite & board level

UK Salary Benchmarks



London premium: +10–20% above national averages
Finance/Tech: +15–30% vs other sectors
Deep Learning / NLP skills: command significant uplift
Large firms: equity & bonus can double

How to Find Data Science Jobs

Data scientist jobs are found through a mix of online platforms, networking, and a demonstration of skills..

Networking
Referrals, LinkedIn, events, and alumni

Online Platforms
LinkedIn, Indeed, Glassdoor

Company Websites
Apply via official career pages

Recruiters
Headhunters match candidates

Portfolio (GitHub/Kaggle)
Showcase projects and coding skills

University Channels
Career fairs, internships, graduate schemes

Conclusion

Data science has established itself as a foundational profession across virtually every industry, driven by the growing reliance on data-informed decision-making. This poster demonstrates that a successful data science career requires a combination of strong quantitative education, continuously updated technical skills, and the soft skills needed to communicate findings effectively to non-technical audiences. Career pathways are flexible - offering both deep specialist and senior leadership trajectories - with compensation that reflects the high demand for expertise. As AI and machine learning continue to evolve, the role of the data scientist will only grow in strategic importance, making it one of the most resilient and rewarding career choices available to graduates today.

References

[1] Provost, F. & Fawcett, T. (2013) Data Science for Business. O'Reilly Media.
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[3] Harnham (2024) Data & AI Salary Guide.
[4] Glassdoor (2024) UK Data Science Salaries.
[5] Interview Query (2025) Data Scientist Career Levels & Compensation.
[6] LinkedIn (2024) Emerging Jobs Report.
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Acknowledgements

This project was completed as part of the coursework for MATH5747M Learning Skills through Case Studies, taught by Xiling Zhang. The authors would like to express sincere gratitude to the module instructor for their guidance and support throughout this work. External data and insights referenced in this poster were drawn from publicly available industry reports by Kaggle, Harnham, Glassdoor, LinkedIn, and the Alan Turing Institute, whose contributions to the data science community are greatly appreciated.